

DRUMMING AND TRANCE

Finnish shamanism



▲ Connecting worlds

To journey to the netherworld, which was ruled by Loviatar, the goddess of shamanism, a shaman would beat a drum to open the *lovi* (a term that meant both door and vagina) that led there.

What is now modern Finland has been populated for 11,000 years by the Finn and Saami people, who migrated there in pursuit of deer as the ice sheets from the last Ice Age finally receded. Both peoples were hunter-gatherers and strong believers in *hatija* (animal spirits), and both are known to have practiced shamanism since at least 10,000 years ago.

Finnish *tietäjät* and Saami *noaidi*, the shamans of their respective pagan cultures, were figures of awesome power and magical knowledge, even outside their own lands: whenever Finns appear in Norse sagas, it is a sign of the supernatural. Finland was said to be a land of wizards, witches, giants, and trolls.

Around 5,000 years ago, the Finnish and Saami cultures diverged as the Finns exchanged

deer hunting for farming, but shamanism persisted in both, even after Scandinavia became Christian. Saami *noaidi* survived into the 1800s, when churches confiscated the last of their sacred drums.

Lost souls

The Finns believed in Tuonela, a netherworld located either underground or somewhere to the north, where the spirits of the dead went. A shaman was thought to be able to travel to Tuonela in a trance to meet spirits and gain wisdom from them. Shamans were sent on their spirit journey with *joiking* (haunting songs) and beating drums. But

they had to trick the ferryman into taking them across the Tuonela River—and take care not to get trapped there in the body of a giant pike.

Pagan Finns believed that a person had three souls: *heinki* (life force); *luonto* (a guardian spirit); and *itse* (personality). Both *luonto* and *itse* could be separated from the body, and could therefore get lost or become stranded in the netherworld. This was thought to cause misfortune and illness. Shamans chanted spells and performed rituals that were believed to heal people or reverse bad luck by strengthening weak spirits or finding lost ones.

Both *tietäjät* and *noaidi* also helped preserve the oral Finnish and Saami cultures through storytelling. In 1835 Elias Lönnrot collected surviving *tietäjät* songs and poems in the *Kalevala*, Finland's national epic, and so created a record of magic traditions.

IN CONTEXT

Bear cult

The pagan Finns revered the animals they hunted, such as elk and bear. Indeed, they held the bear so sacred that its name could not be said. The modern Finnish word for bear, *karhu*, meaning “rough fur,” is one of the euphemisms they used instead.

The Finns believed that the bear came from the sky and could be reincarnated. Whenever a bear was killed and eaten, they would hold the *Karhunpeijaiset* celebration to encourage the bear's soul to return. After the Finns ate bear meat, they buried the bones and set the skull under a sacred pine.

An amulet from the sacred claw of a bear was supposed to bring good luck and help the owner's spirit find its way home.



“... and they draw desirable things to themselves from far off regions in a wondrous way.”

ON SAAMI SHAMANISM, *HISTORIA NORWEGIÆ*, c. 1500